

Breaking the Ceasefire

The Paris Peace Accords allowed the withdrawal of American forces from Vietnam, but did not end the war. Fighting continued between South Vietnamese and communist forces, while political developments in the US undermined support for its allies.

◀ BEFORE

An NVA offensive in Easter 1972 succeeded in occupying substantial areas of South Vietnam, but was halted by American airpower.

AMERICA PUSHES PEACE

Peace talks took on new momentum when the US agreed to accept a ceasefire without the withdrawal of NVA troops. After the **US bombing** of Hanoi and Haiphong, on January 27, 1973 a **peace agreement** was signed by all parties in the war. The withdrawal of US military personnel was completed on March 29, including the return of American **prisoners of war**.



CELEBRATING THE HOMECOMING

Neither side in Vietnam had any intention of observing the provisions of the Paris Peace Accords. President Thieu would not accept the continued presence of North Vietnamese forces inside South Vietnamese borders as legitimate, while the North Vietnamese government still aimed to unite all of Vietnam under communist rule.

Land grabs

In the period immediately before and after the signing of the accords, both sides engaged in land grabs, attempting to extend the area under their control and seize strategic sites. Hundreds of South Vietnamese villages changed hands, some several times, in the attacks and counterattacks across the country. The international commission, which was meant to supervise the ceasefire, proved ineffectual. Armed conflict never stopped.

South Vietnamese forces lost some 25,000 men in combat in 1973, but generally performed better in the piecemeal fighting. The US had flooded Saigon with military equipment before its withdrawal, while North Vietnam took time to recover from losses